

General Knowledge

Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Invasion of Alexander



Invasion of Alexander



Macedonia: The Home of Alexander

- Macedonia was a kingdom located to the north of Greece, in the **Balkan Peninsula**. It was surrounded by **Thrace**, **Epirus**, and **Illyria**.
- Before **Alexander**, Macedonia was a relatively unknown kingdom, overshadowed by the more powerful Greek city-states like **Athens** and **Sparta**.
- Under **King Philip II** (Alexander's father), Macedonia became a dominant military and political power in Greece.
- **Philip II of Macedonia:**
 - **Reign:** 359 BCE – 336 BCE.
 - **Military Reforms:** Philip II restructured the **Macedonian army**, introducing the **phalanx formation** armed with long spears (sarissa), making it highly effective in battle.
 - **Conquest of Greece:** Philip expanded Macedonia's influence by conquering the **Greek city-states** after his victory at the **Battle of Chaeronea** in 338 BCE.

- He formed the **League of Corinth**, uniting most of Greece under Macedonian hegemony.

Alexander's Early Life and Rise to Power

- **Alexander** was born in **356 BCE** in **Pella**, Macedonia. He was tutored by the famous philosopher **Aristotle**, from whom he learned **philosophy, politics, and science**.
- In **336 BCE**, Philip II was assassinated, and Alexander, at the age of **20**, ascended to the Macedonian throne.
 - He quickly established his rule by eliminating rivals and securing the loyalty of the Macedonian army.



Invasion of Alexander the Great and the War with Porus

Background of Alexander's Invasion:

- **Alexander the Great**, the King of Macedonia, embarked on a series of conquests to expand his empire.

- By **334 BCE**, Alexander had successfully conquered **Persia**, and his ambitions led him further east toward the Indian subcontinent.
- The invasion of **India** was a part of Alexander's grand plan to conquer the **known world**.

Reasons for Alexander's Indian Campaign:

- After defeating **Darius III** of Persia, Alexander was drawn to the **riches** and **fertile lands** of India.
- He had also received reports of the **wealth** of the Indian kingdoms, which motivated him to venture further into the subcontinent.
- The **Greeks** had some knowledge of India through the **Persian Empire**, which had territories in present-day Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Alexander's Invasion of India (327 BCE – 325 BCE)

- **Invasion Route:**
 - Alexander's army crossed the **Hindu Kush** mountains into **Bactria** (modern Afghanistan) and continued into the **Indian subcontinent**.
 - His forces passed through **Gandhara** (in modern Pakistan) and proceeded to invade the **Punjab region** of North India.
- **Initial Campaigns:**
 - Alexander faced minor resistance from local rulers like **Ambhi**, the King of **Taxila**, who submitted to him without a fight.
 - **Ambhi**, a strategic ally, provided **Alexander** with troops and supplies for his further campaigns.
- **Porus and the Battle of Hydaspes (326 BCE):**
 - The most significant Indian resistance came from **King Porus** (also known as **Purushottama**) of the **Paurava** kingdom.
 - Porus ruled the region between the **Jhelum** and **Chenab** rivers in modern-day Punjab.



The Battle of Hydaspes:

- **Location:** The battle took place on the **banks of the Jhelum River** (ancient Hydaspes) in **326 BCE**.
- **Forces:**
 - **Alexander** led a seasoned and highly disciplined Macedonian army, comprising cavalry, infantry, archers, and siege weapons.
 - **Porus** commanded a well-equipped Indian army, with a formidable **elephant corps**, which was crucial in Indian warfare.
- **Strategic Movements:**
 - The **Jhelum River** was in full flood during the time of the battle, posing a significant natural barrier.
 - Alexander used a clever strategy to cross the river undetected:
 - He **feigned movements** up and down the riverbank to confuse Porus.

- Alexander secretly moved his troops upstream at night and crossed the river at an **unprotected spot** with part of his army.

- **The Battle:**

- The battle began with **Alexander's forces** engaging Porus' army.
- Porus deployed his **war elephants** at the front, hoping to intimidate Alexander's troops.
- However, Alexander's soldiers managed to **outflank the elephants**, using their speed and discipline to evade the massive animals.
- The Macedonian **cavalry** and **infantry** harassed the elephants with javelins and arrows, causing them to panic and trample Porus' own troops.

- **Porus' Resistance:**

- Despite being outnumbered and facing an advanced military strategy, **Porus fought bravely** and led his army personally.
- His resistance impressed Alexander, who is said to have admired his **valour** and **leadership**.

The outcome of the Battle

- **Defeat of Porus:**

- Porus' army, despite putting up a brave fight, was defeated by Alexander's superior tactics and well-trained forces.
- Porus himself was **captured** after the battle.

- **Aftermath and Treatment of Porus:**

- When brought before Alexander, Porus was asked how he wished to be treated. Porus is famously said to have replied, "**Treat me like a king.**"
- Impressed by his courage and nobility, Alexander not only spared his life but also **restored his kingdom** to him.
- **Porus** was allowed to retain his kingship and was even given additional territories to govern as a **vassal of Alexander**.

Importance of the Battle of Hydaspes

- **Turning Point:** The Battle of Hydaspes was one of the **most important battles** in Alexander's campaign. It demonstrated his military brilliance in overcoming a strong enemy with advanced tactics.
- **Strategic Victory:** Although Alexander won the battle, it was a **costly victory**. His army was **worn out** after years of campaigning, and they were reluctant to continue further into India.
- **Significance of the Elephants:** The battle showcased the power and limitations of the **Elephant Corps** in ancient warfare. The Macedonians, unfamiliar with elephants, managed to devise tactics to counter them effectively.
- **Alexander's Respect for Indian Rulers:** Alexander's treatment of Porus reflects his approach toward local rulers—he often respected those who demonstrated bravery and leadership and allowed them to retain their power under his authority.

Alexander's Further Campaign in India

- **Advance into the Indian Subcontinent:** After the battle, Alexander continued to move deeper into India. He advanced towards the **Beas River**, but his soldiers, exhausted and fearful of facing larger armies further east, **mutinied** and refused to march further.
- **Retreat and Return:**
 - Reluctantly, Alexander decided to **turn back**. He divided his forces:
 - A part of the army sailed down the **Indus River**.
 - Alexander and the remaining forces marched through **Gedrosia (modern-day Baluchistan)** back to Persia, suffering significant losses due to the harsh desert terrain.
- **Establishment of Satrapies:**
 - Before leaving India, Alexander established **Greek satrapies (governorships)** in the conquered territories, ensuring a continued Greek presence in the region.

Impact of Alexander's Indian Campaign

- **Spread of Hellenistic Culture:** Alexander's invasion facilitated the **spread of Hellenistic culture** in the Indian subcontinent, particularly in **art, architecture, and coinage**.
- **Foundation of Cities:** Alexander founded several cities, such as **Alexandria on the Indus** and **Alexandria Bucephala** (in honour of his horse **Bucephalus**, who died after the Battle of Hydaspes).
- **Greek Influence on Indian Culture:** The **Indo-Greek** cultural exchange had long-lasting impacts, especially in **Northwest India**, influencing the subsequent **Indo-Greek Kingdoms**.
- **Political Instability:** Alexander's early departure led to the **fragmentation** of his empire, with **local rulers** reasserting control. This paved the way for the rise of other powerful Indian dynasties like the **Mauryan Empire** under **Chandragupta Maurya**.